

Impact: Low Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Overusing fillers until they sound automatic, impatient or fake — or using encouragers to nudge someone

CORE FORMULA

Cue -> small move -> pause -> observe -> follow or release. -> They trail off mid-thought. You: "mm" — then stay quiet. -> "?and I didn't know what to say." You: "Go on." -> "Yeah." (then nothing — let them keep the floor) -> "Right — and then?"

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Say "mm," "yeah," or "go on" once, then keep listening.

BEST FOR

- Someone is mid-story and doesn't need a question
- A small signal keeps silence from turning awkward, without steering
- You want their thread to stay central, not yours
- They're thinking aloud and just need room to keep going
- On the phone, where a nod won't carry but a quiet sound will
- Early in a hard conversation, before you've earned bigger moves

PHRASE BANK

Sound continuers · Shortest signals

- "Mm."
- "Mm-hm."
- "Yeah."
- "Right."
- "Okay."
- "Sure."
- "Uh-huh."
- "Ah, okay."

Carry-on nudges · Keep them going

- "Go on."
- "Keep going."
- "And then?"
- "So??"
- "Then?"
- "Say more about that."
- "Tell me the rest."
- "Go on, I'm listening."

With-you signals · I'm following

- "I'm with you."
- "That makes sense."
- "I hear you."
- "Yeah, I get that."
- "Of course."
- "That's fair."
- "I can see that."
- "Makes sense so far."

Meeting and call signals · Work conversations

- "Noted."
- "Right, go on."
- "I follow."
- "Understood — keep going."
- "Okay, with you."
- "That tracks."
- "Makes sense — and?"
- "Go ahead."

Ease-off lines · Soften or step back

- "No rush."
- "Take your time."
- "Whenever you're ready."
- "We can stay with this or move on — your call."
- "Only if you want to."
- "No pressure either way."
- "In your own time."
- "Say as much or as little as you like."

Text and message signals · Digital / text

- "Go on?"
- "I'm listening."
- "Mm, keep going."
- "Right, and?"
- "Still with you."
- "Say more?"
- "Ah, I see."
- "Yeah — then?"

When it's tense · Pressure / conflict

- "Okay. Go on."
- "I'm listening — take your time."
- "Yeah. Keep going, I want to understand."
- "Right. What else?"
- "I'm here. Say it however it comes out."
- "Go on — I'm not going anywhere."
- "Take the time you need."
- "Okay. And what's under that?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Too broad, too fast — "Tell me everything."

Better: One small continuer: "mm" or "go on."

Best: One continuer, then stop and watch how they respond before adding another.

2. Weak: Filling the gap with your own take — "You're overthinking this."

Better: "Yeah."

Best: "Yeah." — then silence, so the floor stays theirs.

3. Weak: Correcting them — "That's not right."

Better: "Right."

Best: "I might be reading it wrong — go on."

DECISION TREE

If They add detail after your signal

Follow the thread — stay with what they raised.
"Go on."

If They pause to think

Wait. Don't fill it — let them find the next line.

If They look uncomfortable or go guarded

Release the move and ease the pressure.
"No rush — we don't have to stay with this."

If They ask for advice

Switch to Permission-based advice (TC027).
"Want my honest read, or just a sounding board?"

If Something actually needs doing

Stop encouraging and act — give the answer or take the step.
"Okay — here's what I'd do."

SCENARIOS

Casual chat

Use the smallest move — a sound and a nod — so they keep the story. — *"Mm — go on."*

Professional / meeting

Keep it concise and non-performative; signal you're tracking without interrupting. — *"Right, with you — keep going."*

Conflict or upset

Pair the encourager with validation or an autonomy release; never use it to steer. — *"Okay. Take your time — say it however it comes."*

Digital / text

One sentence only — a single line that says "still here". — *"I'm listening — go on."*

High-stakes

Lead with direct clarity first; add a minimal encourager only if it lowers the pressure. — *"Understood. Go on — I want to get this right."*

Phone call

Swap the nod for a quiet sound so they can hear you're still there. — *"Mm-hm."*

WHEN NOT TO USE

- They've asked you a direct question — answer it
- Encouragement would pressure them to disclose more than they want
- You're not actually listening — an empty "mm" is worse than silence
- The moment needs a decision or direct action, not more talking
- Physical safety or an emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the openings

Write down five moments from today's conversations where a small continuer would have kept someone talking.

Day 2 — Build the ladder

Take one of those moments and write a weak, a better and a best response for it.

Day 3 — Cut it back

Shorten your best response by a third. Notice how little is actually needed to signal you're with them.

Day 4 — Stock the sounds

Say your shortlist out loud — "mm", "yeah", "go on", "right" — until they sound like you, not a technique.

Day 5 — One and stop

In a low-stakes chat, use a single encourager, then go quiet and watch what the other person does with the space.

Day 6 — Add a release

Practise one easing-off line for when someone tenses — e.g. "No rush, we don't have to stay with this."

Day 7 — Full pass

In a real conversation, run cue -> small move -> pause -> observe -> follow or release — and notice the moment to stop entirely.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I preserve their autonomy, or steer them?
- Did I use one move rather than stacking several?
- Did I actually watch how they responded?
- Did I stop when their energy dropped?
- Would silence have done the job better?
- Was I genuinely listening, or just making the sounds?